ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

MEL 101: Introduction to Modern European Languages

French and German foundations: sounds, gender and basic structures

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Modern European Languages | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack covers the first-semester foundations of French and German: pronunciation and silent letters, articles and gender, basic verb conjugation, word order, and the study habits that make a foreign language stick. It also explains how to use a dictionary properly.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Pronounce basic French and German sounds accurately.
- Use definite and indefinite articles with correct gender.
- Conjugate common verbs in the present tense.
- Build correct simple sentences in each language.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Sounds and spelling

Spelling and sound diverge; learn both together.

- French: nasal vowels, liaisons and silent final consonants.
- French: accent marks affect pronunciation and meaning.
- German: umlauts, the ich and ach sounds, and final devoicing.
- German: nouns are capitalised; compounds carry meaning in parts.
- Read aloud daily; silent reading builds no pronunciation.
- Use audio from the start rather than translating word by word.

Gender, articles and agreement

Gender is grammatical, not logical.

- French: le, la, les; un, une, des.
- German: der, die, das; ein, eine, ein; cases change articles.
- Adjectives agree with the noun in gender and number.
- Word order: German places the finite verb second in main clauses.
- Negation patterns differ from English; learn them as whole phrases.
- Record nouns with their article from the first day.

> **Learn the article with the noun**
> Memorising 'Tisch' without 'der' guarantees errors later. Learn 'der Tisch' as one item.

Study routine and resources

Language learning rewards frequency over intensity.

- Twenty minutes daily beats three hours once a week.
- Use spaced repetition for vocabulary with audio.
- Speak from week one, even imperfectly.
- Keep an error log and review it weekly.
- Read a dictionary entry properly: gender, part of speech, example.
- Watch/listen to authentic material with subtitles, then without.

Why a European language, and which one

Modern European languages are studied in Nigeria for practical and scholarly reasons: diplomatic and trade relations, access to scholarship, translation, tourism, and the comparative study of language itself. French is the most widely taught because of Nigeria's francophone neighbours and regional bodies; German, Spanish, Portuguese, Russian and Arabic-related programmes exist with smaller cohorts.

Learning a language is not learning a code of translations. It is learning a system with its own categories: gender in French and German, case in German and Russian, aspect in Russian, the subjunctive as a living mood in French and Spanish. These are not decoration; they change what must be said and what can be left unsaid.

The comparison with Nigerian languages is genuinely illuminating. Learners who speak a tonal language often find European stress patterns easier; learners whose first language lacks grammatical gender find noun gender the hardest feature; learners from a language without articles find French partitives puzzling.

The four skills and how to build them

Listening, speaking, reading and writing develop unevenly and need separate practice. Reading can be built quickly with graded texts and a dictionary; listening requires repeated exposure to natural speed; speaking requires tolerating error; writing requires learning register and connectors.

Comprehensible input is the engine. Read and listen to material slightly above your level, repeatedly, with the aim of understanding rather than translating word by word. Grammar study then explains what you have already noticed, which is the opposite of the common classroom order and far more durable.

Vocabulary should be learned in chunks, not isolated words: "avoir besoin de", "es geht um", "tener ganas de". Chunks carry grammar and usage inside them, so they produce correct sentences earlier. Aim for high-frequency vocabulary first: the most common thousand words cover most everyday speech.

> **Speak before you are ready**
> Waiting until your grammar is correct guarantees you will not speak. Error correction is information, not humiliation - and in a foreign language it is how fluency is built.

Culture, register and translation

Language carries social rules. French distinguishes tu and vous; German distinguishes du and Sie; Spanish varies between tú, usted and vos by region. Choosing wrongly is a social error even when the grammar is perfect. Learning when to use which form is part of the language.

Register matters in writing: a formal letter, an academic essay and a message to a friend use different structures and vocabulary. Learn the formulas early - salutations, closings, hedging phrases - because they are fixed and high-value.

Translation is a skill with its own discipline. A good translation preserves function rather than word order; idioms rarely transfer; and some cultural references need explanation rather than substitution. Never translate word by word, and always read the result as a text in the target language.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Building a first paragraph in the target language

You must write 120 words about your studies in French, German or Spanish.

1. Collect five sentence frames rather than vocabulary: "Je suis étudiant(e) en...", "Depuis...", "Ce qui me plaît, c'est...".
2. Fill each frame with content you can actually say.
3. Check gender and agreement for every noun and adjective.
4. Add two connectors appropriate to the register.
5. Read aloud and mark anything you cannot pronounce confidently.
6. Have it corrected once, then rewrite from memory.

> **What to carry forward**
> Frames plus accurate agreement produce usable writing faster than word lists.

2. Handling a listening exercise

You understand nothing on first hearing. What is the method?

1. Listen once without stopping for the gist only - who is speaking, about what, in what mood.
2. Listen again and note the words you recognise, not the ones you do not.
3. Identify the type of text: announcement, interview, conversation, advertisement.
4. Answer the questions you can, then listen a third time for the specific missing details.
5. Check your answers against the transcript and locate why you missed each one.

> **What to carry forward**
> Gist first, detail second, transcript third. Never start with word-by-word decoding.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain how grammatical gender affects learning a European language for a Nigerian learner.

15 marks

1. Define grammatical gender as a noun class system affecting agreement.
2. Explain the difficulty where the first language lacks gender.
3. Show the consequences: articles, adjectives, pronouns must agree.
4. Describe a learning strategy: learn the article with the noun.
5. Note that gender is largely arbitrary and cannot be guessed from meaning.

Q2. Discuss the relationship between language learning and cultural understanding.

20 marks

1. Give examples where grammar encodes social relations: tu/vous, du/Sie.
2. Show how politeness formulas differ.
3. Explain the risk of translating cultural concepts directly.
4. Argue that language learning is also learning a social system.
5. Conclude on the limits: fluency does not guarantee cultural competence.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Grammatical gender. A noun class system requiring agreement in articles, adjectives and pronouns.

Register. The level of formality appropriate to situation and audience.

Comprehensible input. Language slightly above the learner's level that can be understood from context.

Cognate. A word related in form and meaning across languages.

False friend. A word that looks similar across languages but means something different.

Subjunctive. A verb mood expressing doubt, wish, necessity or emotion, productive in French and Spanish.

Case. A system marking a noun's grammatical role, as in German and Russian.

Chunk. A memorised multi-word unit used as a single building block.

Agreement. Correspondence of gender, number or case between related words.

Tú / vous. The familiar and formal second-person pronouns in French, used according to social relation.

Idiom. A fixed expression whose meaning is not derivable from its parts.

Transliteration. Representing words of one writing system in another's characters.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Sounds

Pronunciation.

- Learn the phoneme inventory of your target language.
- Read aloud daily for five minutes.
- Record and compare with a model speaker.

Week 2 - Nouns

Gender and articles.

- Learn 50 nouns with their articles.
- Practise agreement in short sentences.
- Build a gender-grouped vocabulary list.

Week 3 - Verbs

Present and past.

- Conjugate five core verbs.
- Write ten sentences about your week.
- Learn five high-frequency chunks.

Week 4 - Text

Reading and writing.

- Read a graded text and summarise it.
- Write 120 words on a familiar topic.
- Check register and formulas.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Your course textbook for the target language, including its audio component.
- A bilingual dictionary with usage examples rather than word lists only.
- Graded readers at your level for extensive reading practice.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why learn a noun with its article?

Answer: Gender is not predictable from meaning, so the article must be memorised as part of the word.

2. What is liaison in French?

Answer: The pronunciation of a normally silent final consonant when the next word begins with a vowel or silent h.

3. Where does the finite verb sit in a German main clause?

Answer: In second position.

4. How do umlauts affect German vowels?

Answer: They change vowel quality, and often the plural or comparative form of the word.

5. Why is daily short practice better?

Answer: Frequency strengthens recall and pronunciation habits more effectively than infrequent long sessions.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Learn the alphabet and core sounds in each language.
- [ ] Record yourself reading a short paragraph weekly.
- [ ] Build a 100-word vocabulary list with articles.
- [ ] Conjugate five common verbs in the present.
- [ ] Write ten correct simple sentences.
- [ ] Set up a spaced-repetition deck with audio.
- [ ] Keep a weekly error log.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | Faculty Primer | 100L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

MEL 101: Introduction to Modern European Languages